

### CULTIVARS

- Fairy Tale
- Nadia
- Orient Express
- Orient Charm
- Hansel

### INTENSIVE SPACING

- 1 rows per bed spaced every 18” (45 cm) on the row.

### FERTILIZATION

- Eggplants are heavy feeders that stay in the garden for 100 + day . We front-load the total amount of fertility requirement at the initial bed prep stage and do not top dressed them afterwards.
- Apply lots of compost, +/- 1.5 inch (7 cm) all across the bed along with a dose of nitrogen-rich organic fertilizers like pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2) and alfalfa meal (2-0-2). Also, add potassium sulfate (0-0-50) and organic Sul-Po-Mag (0-0-22)

### IRRIGATION

#### Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) : Under plastic mulch.
- No sprinkler to keep foliage dry and thus prevent diseases.

#### Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Medium (24”-40”)
- General: Constant and even moisture from flower through fruit. Eggplants like to dry down before being watered again.

## STARTING SEEDS

- Start transplants 7-8 weeks before transplantation date. Sow seeds in 128 cell flats in seed-starting soil mix. 1 seed per cell.
- Place trays on heating mats and maintain floor temperature at 80 °F (27 °C) until emergence.
- After emergence, maintain the ambient temperature in the nursery around 75°F (24 °C) during the day and 65°F (18 °C) at night. The soil-mix must be kept moist at all times.
- Pot-up in 4" (10cm) pots 3 weeks after sowing.
- Plants are ready to transplant when the seedlings are about 7–8 weeks old they should be 10–12" (25-30 cm) tall. Ideally, they will have some flowers that are open or ready to open.
- Harden off plants by exposing them to outside temperatures and reducing water for 4-5 days before transplanting

## IMPLANTATION

Eggplants are planted once a year and like bell peppers and field tomatoes are heat-loving crops that like to be grown under cover (tunnels, caterpillars).

## EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- Broadfork
- 30" bed prep rake
- Landscape fabric, staples, drip tape and fittings.
- 4' (1.2M) steel bars (cement rods); 1 stake every 3 plants.

## TRANSPLANT ITINERARY

- Before transplanting, make sure minimum soil temperature is above 60°F (16°C ), 20°C is optimal.
- Pass through with the broadfork.
- Remove large debris from the bed if needed (use flail mower, rake or manually remove the large chunks).
- Apply compost and amendments in the middle of the bed and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2.5" (6 cm). Since the bed is covered with landscape fabric, it needs not to be clean up with another pass of the rake.

- Install 4 lines of drip tape per bed and start the system. Fix leaks at that point, if any.
- Lay down landscape fabric and secured with staples each second step (5' or 1.5 m). It needs to be tight.
- Transplant bell peppers making sure to extract the seedlings from their pots delicately. When putting them in the ground, the soil level on seedling should end up being quite level with the soil.
- Using a sledgehammer, drive stakes 12' (30 cm) deep into the ground every 5' (1.8M).
- Water the bed thoroughly the first time, keeping the soil moist for the first week after the transplant.
- Once the plants have reached +/- 16" (40 cm) high, install the first line of bailing twine, crossing it from the inside-out of each stake. Basket-weaves the plants 1 or 2 more times as they grow every 12" (30cm).

## **WEEDING**

- Weed through the holes of the landscape fabric 2 or 3 times in the season.

## **MAINTENANCE**

- We do not prune the eggplants.

## **PLANT PROTECTION**

- Young eggplant plants are susceptible to Colorado potato beetles. Weekly scouting should be schedule as both adults and larvae can quickly defoliate plants. Control by hand and, in the case of an infestation, use the recommended organic-farming dosage of Entrust.
- If plants are flowering but fail to set fruit, the problem is likely (at least in northern regions) the tarnished plant bug, which particularly appreciates the sap of eggplant a pepper flowers. In the case of an infestation, use the recommended organic-farming dosage of Spinosad

## **HARVEST**

- Harvesting is done twice a week using a pruner and tree planting bags.
- Eggplants are ready to harvest when they are the size wanted, but they should be firm.
- Leave about a ¾" (2 cm) inch stem on the fruit.
- Only eggplants that are free of blemishes are harvested. The rest are picked and discarded in the pathways.

## **CONDITIONING**

- Eggplants are not washed but must be wiped clean if dirty.

## **STORING**

- Eggplants are stored in cold room kept at 47 °F (8 °C) and should not be stored for more than 4 days before being sold.